



“Anyone who has to fight...
against an enemy in
complete command of the
air fights like a savage
against modern European
troops... with the same
chances of success.”

FIELD MARSHALL ERWIN ROMMEL
FROM THE POSTHUMOUS *ROMMEL PAPERS* (1953)

THUNDERBOLT FIGHTER-BOMBER

The Republic P-47 Thunderbolt was produced in greater numbers than any other American fighter in World War II. A large, heavy single-seater, the P-47 proved effective both in air-to-air combat and as a ground-attack aircraft. It was flying in Thunderbolts that Francis S. Gabreski, the war's top American ace in Europe, recorded his 28 kills.



COMMAND OF THE AIR

**FROM THE START OF WORLD WAR II, AIRCRAFT WERE
CRUCIAL TO THE SUCCESS OF ARMY OPERATIONS AS
TROOPS WERE EXPOSED TO FIRE FROM THE SKY**

ON SEPTEMBER 1, 1939, Germany invaded Poland. Four weeks later the Polish forces surrendered and their country was divided between Germany and the Soviet Union. If anyone still had doubts about the importance of air power in warfare, this lightning campaign ended them. The Luftwaffe sent about 2,000 aircraft into Poland – a relatively small force compared with air operations later in World War II, but more than enough to overcome the few hundred airplanes of the Polish air force, despite the skill and gallantry with which its pilots fought. In command of the air, German aircraft battered Polish ground

troops, clearing a path for advancing armor, shattered Polish rail and road networks, and, in a climactic gesture of terror and destruction, reduced much of Warsaw to burning ruins.

The Polish campaign was the first example of *Blitzkrieg*, the “lightning war” of short devastating mobile campaigns, which would give the Germans control of Denmark and Norway in April 1940, France and the Low Countries in the following

